The New Nationalism

Theodore Roosevelt · Osawatomie, Kansas · August 31, 1910 · excerpts

Source: Theodore Roosevelt Center, theodorerooseveltcenter.org; speech reprinted in The New Nationalism (1910).

Two years out of office and growing restless under his successor Taft, Theodore Roosevelt gave this speech at the dedication of a John Brown memorial. It launched his progressive agenda — graduated income and inheritance taxes, federal regulation of corporations, and stronger executive power — and previewed his 1912 Bull Moose campaign. He framed strong federal action as the necessary modern equivalent of Hamiltonian nationalism.

Connect: TR's push for a strong federal government echoes Hamilton's original Federalist argument (Class 6). Trace one line from Hamilton to TR.

Key Passages

On corporate power

> The absence of effective State, and, especially, national, restraint upon unfair money-getting has tended to create a small class of enormously wealthy and economically powerful men, whose chief object is to hold and increase their power. The prime need is to change the conditions which enable these men to accumulate power which it is not for the general welfare that they should hold or exercise.

The Square Deal

> When I say that I am for the square deal, I mean not merely that I stand for fair play under the present rules of the game, but that I stand for having those rules changed so as to work for a more substantial equality of opportunity and of reward.

New Nationalism

> The New Nationalism puts the national need before sectional or personal advantage. … It demands that representative government … represent all the people rather than any one class or section of the people.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Historical Reasoning — Comparison (1 pt): Write a thesis comparing TR's New Nationalism with Wilson's New Freedom in the 1912 election.

2. Identify ONE specific reform TR demands and ONE specific reform he does NOT (e.g., women's suffrage).

3. How does this speech anticipate the New Deal a generation later?